

Pre-DP *only* lacks sufficiency readings

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von Stechow and Iatridou (2007) note that (1a) with pre-vP *only* can have a weak “sufficiency reading” where going to the North End is one way to get good cheese, but is not necessarily required, contrary to the typical assumption that *only* ϕ implies ϕ (Horn, 1969).

- (1) a. To get good cheese, you only have to go to [the North End]_F. (*only* > $\square$)
b. $\nrightarrow$ To get good cheese, you have to go to the North End.
c. $\leadsto$ To get good cheese, you can go to the North End.

Relatedly, Taglicht (1984) observes that, while pre-vP *only*’s scope is frozen in (2a), pre-DP *only*’s scope in (2b) is flexible: only the latter has an *only* > $\square$ reading paraphrasable as *You only have to read MACBETH*.

- (2) a. You have to only read [Macbeth]_F. ($\square$ > *only*, **only* > $\square$)
b. You have to read only [Macbeth]_F. ($\square$ > *only*, *only* > $\square$)

Naturally, we expect to see sufficiency readings with pre-DP *only*. However, in (3b), we don’t seem to get a sufficiency reading, unlike (3a).

- (3) **Context:** You can pass the class by reading either Macbeth or Hamlet, and Macbeth is considered easier as it’s shorter. Neither is required.
- a. To pass the class, you only have to read [Macbeth]_F.
 $\nrightarrow$ You have to read Macbeth.
 $\leadsto$ You can read Macbeth. True
- b. To pass the class, you have to read only [Macbeth]_F.
 $\leadsto$ You have to read Macbeth. False

Is this lack of a sufficiency reading predicted? Condoravdi and Francez (2022) attribute sufficiency readings to contextual modal domain restriction. But as long as pre-DP *only* has an *only* > $\square$ parse, the same domain restriction mechanism should lead to a sufficiency reading.

What about the syntactic account of sufficiency readings in Alonso-Ovalle and Hirsch (2022)? The account postulates an additional covert focus operator in the modal preajacent in (1a) associating with the DP. If we assume that *only DP* forms a quantifier and QRs to a high position (Rooth, 1985), the syntactic account might predict the lack of a sufficiency reading in (3b): if *only DP* moves above the modal, the covert operator might not be able to associate with the DP.

However, the QR approach to the flexible scope of pre-DP *only* is controversial. Recent authors have instead attributed the flexible scope-taking of pre-DP *only* to a covert (propositional) exclusive particle ONLY, which can scope high, with *only* just realizing an inert element in (2b) (see e.g. Hirsch, 2017). But in that case, there is no notable syntactic/semantic difference between pre-vP and pre-DP *only* on the ONLY > $\square$ parse. Sufficiency readings should also arise for pre-DP *only*.

Finally, the *only*/ONLY > $\square$ scope assumption is rejected by von Stechow and Iatridou's analysis of (1a)'s sufficiency reading. They decompose *only* into negation and an exceptive operator, and propose that they split around $\square$ there. But this doesn't obviously predict the lack of a sufficiency reading of (3b), as the possible explanation the syntactic account has, based on having two focus operators, doesn't seem available here.

References

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